

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

me to live off credit because, in his words, “that’s what it is there for – what’s the point of having it otherwise?” We didn’t have a penny of savings between us, having (thankfully) forgotten about my ISA by this point. When a debt collector turned up because of an accident my partner had had, which I knew nothing about, my parents had to bail us out. They did this more times than I care to remember.’

Since splitting from her partner, it’s been a rocky path to recovery for Charlotte, but she’s getting there. ‘Once we had split up and sold the house, I finally had some savings again, but I also had a new-born baby and no child support to claim. I was still living in this cycle of living in debt and maxing out credit on cards, store accounts – you name it, I had it.

‘I was able to clear some of it using my forgotten ISA, but the cycle just continued. By the time it got really out of control, I had used all the savings I had from the ISA and the house sale, and I was back at maximum balances. My parents would clear it all off, I would set up a standing order to pay them back, and start the cycle all over again. At one point I was receiving so much mail that my mother, who I lived with, googled the addresses on the back of the envelopes, and quickly worked out the problem without having to open the letters.

‘Not until I was twenty-nine did I realize that I had to stop this. I didn’t want to be thirty and living with my parents, with my own child. Only since the pandemic have I become completely debt free. I’ve been fortunate to have been able to do my job